Donbas Was Invaded, Not "Lost"

Debate notes: taking apart the myth that eastern Ukrainians were "pro-Russian" and that this caused the 2014 occupation

Prepared for Arthur Tkachenko · 3 November 2026 · Every number carries an inline source tag [R#]; full list at the end. If a number is not in these notes, do not improvise it on stage.

The thesis in one breath

The occupation of Donbas in 2014 was an **imported war**: started by a Russian ex-FSB officer with a squad from Crimea, run by a Moscow political consultant as "prime minister", steered by Kremlin officials on tape, and found by the European Court of Human Rights to be under **Russian effective control from 11 May 2014**. The people of Donetsk and Luhansk voted 84% for Ukrainian independence in 1991, were majority ethnic Ukrainian in both Soviet and Ukrainian censuses, never gave secession a majority in any credible poll, and the miners among them helped break the Soviet Union in the first place. Language is not loyalty, and a minority opinion is not a mandate for tanks.

How to use these notes

- **Three-step rhythm** for every point: claim (one sentence) → number (one figure, one source) → example (a person, a city, a date) → zinger. Then stop talking.
- **Concede small, win big.** The opponent will bring real numbers (Customs Union polls, the 2019 Opposition Platform vote, the 1993 autonomy strike). Section 11 and the rebuttal table own those first.
- **Make them define terms.** "Pro-Russian" can mean: speaks Russian, likes cheaper gas, votes Party of Regions, or wants to be annexed. Only the last one could ever "justify" anything, and it never had a majority.

See also (my earlier pieces; tone reference, not repeated here):

- The Linguistic Survivorship: Why "Russian-Speaking Regions" Are a Stupid Myth: hackernoon.com/the-linguistic-survivorship-why-russian-speaking-regions-are-a-stupid-myth
- Why Imperial Historians Want You to Forget Kharkiv's Real Story: hackernoon.com/why-imperial-historians-want-you-to-forget-kharkivs-real-story-breaking-the-myths
- #FreeYakutia: How a Viral Meme Turned Into a Conversation About Independence: hackernoon.com/freeyakutia-how-a-viral-meme-turned-into-a-conversation-about-independence

Cheat sheet: the 10 numbers to memorise

If you only get 90 seconds, use these. Each one is a complete argument on its own.

#	Number	What it proves	Source
1	**83.90%** Donetsk, **83.86%** Luhansk voted YES to independence, 1 Dec 1991	Donbas chose Ukraine, by about 5 to 1. Even counting every registered voter (including no-shows), 64% / 68% said yes.	[R1]
2	**173 of 226** Donbas collieries struck, July 1989; **500,000+** strike participants in Ukraine	Donbas workers helped crack the Soviet system from inside, two years before 1991.	[R24]
3	**56.9%** Donetsk, **58.0%** Luhansk: ethnic Ukrainians, 2001 census (up from 50.7% / 51.9% in 1989)	An ethnic Ukrainian majority in both censuses, and it grew.	[R2]
4	**58.7%** of ethnic Ukrainians in Donetsk oblast named Russian as their native language (2001)	Russian-speaking ≠ Russian. Language is the scar of Russification, not proof of loyalty.	[R3]
5	**27.5%** Donetsk, **30.3%** Luhansk backed secession to join Russia; **52.2% / 51.9%** opposed (KIIS, April 2014)	Even at peak propaganda, with gunmen already in the streets, separatism was a minority.	[R8]
6	**18.1%** Donetsk, **24.4%** Luhansk supported armed seizure of government buildings (April 2014)	Four in five did not back the method. The "uprising" lacked the people.	[R8]
7	**About 50** armed men from Crimea took Sloviansk on 12 April 2014 under Igor Girkin, a Russian ex-FSB officer	"I'm the one who pulled the trigger of war" (Girkin, Nov 2014). The war had a Russian ignition key.	[R13][R14]
8	**11 May 2014**: the date from which the ECHR found Russia had effective control of the separatist areas	The highest European court ruled this was Russia, not a civil war.	[R19][R20]
9	**980,000** registered IDPs inside Ukraine by Feb 2015 vs **~600,000** who sought asylum or other legal stay abroad, mainly in Russia	More people fled to Ukraine than abroad, Russia included. People vote with their feet.	[R27]
10	**~55%** of residents of the occupied "DNR/LNR" preferred to belong to Ukraine (ZOiS survey, 2019)	Even after 5 years of occupation and propaganda, a majority of those still there wanted Ukraine.	[R12]

Two backup numbers: Pew, April 2014: **70%** of eastern Ukrainians wanted Ukraine to stay united, including **58%** of people who speak only Russian [R10]. KIIS, May 2022: **68%** in the East rejected any territorial concessions to Russia, even with fighting on their doorstep [R11].

1. 1991: Donbas voted for Ukraine, about five to one

CLAIM The one time Donbas got a free, legal choice between Moscow and Kyiv, it chose Kyiv by a landslide.

NUMBERS

- Referendum of 1 Dec 1991, YES share of votes cast: **Donetsk 83.90%, Luhansk 83.86%**, Kharkiv 86.33%, Dnipropetrovsk 90.36%, Odesa 85.38%. National headline: **90.32%** (28.8 million yes), turnout 84.18% [R1].
- YES as a share of **all registered voters**, no-shows included: Donetsk **64%**, Luhansk **68%**. A majority of the whole electorate said yes in every region except Crimea and Sevastopol [R1].
- The only regions below 60% were Crimea (54.19%) and Sevastopol (57.07%), home of Russia's Black Sea Fleet. Donbas sits with Kharkiv and Odesa, not with Crimea [R1].
- Ethnic Russians in Ukraine: an estimated **55%** voted for independence [R39].
- Polling momentum in autumn 1991: support rose from **63%** (Sept) to **77%** (early Oct) to **88%** (mid-Nov) [R1].

EXAMPLE Political economist Vlad Mykhnenko sums up the Donbas result as **84% for independence on a turnout approaching 80%** [R24]. That was not a reluctant yes. The miners, the steelworkers, and the Russian-speaking engineers turned out and voted to leave the USSR.

ZINGER ***If Donbas was "always Russian", it had a strange way of showing it: five in six of its voters picked Ukraine.***

2. The miners who broke the Soviet Union (1989–1991)

CLAIM Donbas coal miners were not Moscow's loyal base. They were the Kremlin's nightmare: organised, self-run strike committees that shut the USSR's energy heart and turned economic anger into political demands against Gorbachev and for Ukrainian sovereignty.

NUMBERS

- **Be precise:** the July 1989 strike **began in Kuzbass** (Mezhdurechensk, Siberia) on 10–11 July 1989. Donbas joined within days and became one of its biggest centres [R22][R24].
- Donbas's first mine walked out on **15 July 1989**. On 17 July about **2,000** miners struck in Makiivka. That same day the LA Times counted 110,000 strikers in Siberia and 8 Donets Basin mines already out [R24] [R23].
- At the peak: **173 of 226** Donbas collieries on strike; strike participants in Ukraine exceeded **500,000** [R24]. USSR-wide, over **400,000** miners [R22].
- Outcome: a Soviet government commission flew to Donetsk on 20 July and conceded; by September 1989 Volodymyr Shcherbytsky, Brezhnev-era boss of Soviet Ukraine since 1972, was gone [R22][R24].
- **March 1991, the second all-Union strike:** Ukrainian miners demanded **Gorbachev's resignation**, dissolution of the Congress of People's Deputies, and **constitutional status for Ukraine's Declaration of State Sovereignty**. It ran about two months and ended only after the mines were transferred to the republics [R25][R22].
- Economic impact: Soviet coal output fell **5%** from 1989 to 1990 and **18%** from 1990 to 1991 [R22].
- Historian Rudolf Simon: the 1989 strike "initiated a process of delegitimation from which the regime never recovered" [R22]. Siegelbaum: in Ukraine "miners voted overwhelmingly for independence in the referendum of December 1, 1991" [R25].

Honesty clause: the 1989 demands were mostly economic (soap, wages, housing, local self-management), and strikers then were wary of outside nationalist activists [R24]. The political turn came in 1990–91. Say "Donbas miners turned against the Soviet centre", not "Donbas miners demanded independence in 1989".

EXAMPLE Mykhailo Volynko, a miners' union leader from Luhansk oblast, recalled that miners from **Pervomaisk** helped raise the Ukrainian flag over Kyiv City Council in 1990 [R38]. The same Pervomaisk was later occupied by Russian proxies. Put that on a slide: the flag those men raised in 1990 was torn down by imported gunmen in 2014.

ZINGER ***The men who dug the Soviet Union's coal also dug its grave. Don't tell me Donbas was nostalgic for the USSR. Donbas went on strike against it.***

3. Census: an ethnic Ukrainian majority that kept growing

CLAIM "Eastern Ukraine is ethnically Russian" is false on the Soviet Union's own numbers, and more false on Ukraine's.

NUMBERS

- Donetsk oblast: **Ukrainians 56.9%**, Russians 38.2% (2001); in 1989: Ukrainians 50.7%, Russians 43.6% [R2].
- Luhansk oblast: **Ukrainians 58.0%**, Russians 39.0% (2001); in 1989: 51.9% vs 44.8% [R2].
- Kharkiv oblast: Ukrainians 70.7% (2001, up from 62.8%); Dnipropetrovsk: 79.3% (up from 71.6%) [R2].
- Native language, 2001: Donetsk oblast Russian **74.9%** / Ukrainian 24.1%; Luhansk Russian **68.8%** / Ukrainian 30.0% [R3][R4].
- The key split: **58.7%** of ethnic Ukrainians in Donetsk oblast and **49.4%** in Luhansk oblast named Russian as their native language [R3][R4]. Ethnicity and language point in different directions, so "language = nationality" breaks right here.
- Ukraine overall (2001): Ukrainians 77.8%, Russians 17.3%; native Ukrainian 67.5%, Russian 29.6% [R2].

Do not use the 1989-vs-2001 native-language change figures for Donetsk or Luhansk: the census commentary contradicts itself on them. The ethnicity figures are clean.

EXAMPLE Donetsk city: **87.8%** Russian native speakers. Mariupol: **89.6%** [R6]. Both cities are in the most Russian-speaking part of Ukraine. Mariupol was taken back by Ukraine on **13 June 2014** [R30] and stayed Ukrainian for eight years until Russia flattened it in 2022. If language made people Russian, Mariupol would have been the easiest prize of 2014. It took a full-scale invasion and a siege.

ZINGER ***Language is a tool, not a passport. Otherwise the Irish would be English and Americans would still pay tax to London.***

4. 2014 polls: separatism was a loud minority, never a majority

CLAIM Opponents say "the polls showed Donbas wanted Russia." The polls showed the opposite: a minority that propaganda and gunmen made look like a people.

NUMBERS

- Pew (April 2014, 1,659 interviews): **70%** of eastern Ukrainians said Ukraine should stay united, including **58% of Russian-only speakers**. Nationally 77% [R10].
- Donetsk Institute of Social Research (March 2014): 18.2% backed Donetsk joining Russia; all separatist options combined **31.6%** vs **50.2%** for options inside Ukraine [R40].
- KIIS Feb 2014 national trend: support for merging with Russia fell from **20% (2008) to 9% (Nov 2013)**. Even in the East, **72.2%** wanted two independent but friendly states. Only **31.8% of ethnic Russians** in Ukraine wanted one state [R7].
- The April 2014 KIIS poll was taken **8–16 April**, the same week Girkin's men seized Sloviansk. Even then, over half of Donetsk and Luhansk said no [R8].

Poll / date	Donetsk	Luhansk	Kharkiv	Dnipro	Source
KIIS Feb 2014: unite Ukraine and Russia into one state	33.2%	24.1%	15.1%	13.8%	[R7]
KIIS Apr 2014: secede and join Russia (for)	27.5%	30.3%	16.1%	6.9%	[R8]
KIIS Apr 2014: secede and join Russia (against)	52.2%	51.9%	65.6%	84.1%	[R8]
KIIS Apr 2014: support armed seizure of buildings	18.1%	24.4%	n/a	n/a	[R8]
KIIS Apr 2014: would welcome invading Russian troops	12.6%	11.7%	n/a	n/a	[R8]
KIIS 2021–Feb 2022 (govt-controlled Donetsk): unify with Russia	10% for / 86% independent				[R9]

EXAMPLE Look at Luhansk in April 2014: **24.4%** supported seizing buildings and **19.3%** supported Russian troops coming in, yet **11.7%** said they would actually welcome an invasion [R8]. That is your "popular uprising": about one in eight. Every revolution needs the people; this one needed a border crossing.

ZINGER ***A minority opinion is not a mandate for tanks. If 30% of Texans like Mexican food, Mexico doesn't get Texas.***

5. Who pulled the trigger: the Russian chain of command, in their own words

CLAIM The war did not grow out of Donbas soil. It was carried in, armed, staffed and financed from Russia, and the men who did it later bragged about it.

NUMBERS

- **Igor Girkin ("Strelkov")**: Russian citizen, former FSB officer. On **12 April 2014** he seized Sloviansk with about **50** armed men who came from Crimea. The first combat death came the next day: SBU officer **Hennadiy Bilichenko**, 13 April [R14].
- Girkin, Zavtra interview, 20 Nov 2014: **"I'm the one who pulled the trigger of war. If our squad hadn't crossed the border, it all would have ended like in Kharkiv or Odesa."** [R13]
- Girkin was the DPR's "defence minister" from 16 May to 14 Aug 2014. On **17 Nov 2022** a Dutch court convicted him in absentia of murder over **MH17 (298 killed)**, sentenced him to life, and found that Russia had overall control over the DPR forces [R14].
- **Alexander Borodai**: Muscovite, Moscow political consultant, DPR "prime minister" from 16 May 2014 [R15]. NYT, 1 June 2014: a "fast-talking Muscovite… commanding what he says are hundreds of fighters from Russia" [R15]. Today he is a **United Russia deputy in the Russian Duma** (since 2021).

- **Surkov leaks**: an email from an employee of a Russian investment firm sent a candidate list for the DPR "government" to Kremlin aide Vladislav Surkov's office days before that government was announced [R16].
- **Glazyev tapes** (released 2016): Putin adviser Sergey Glazyev instructs activists in Kharkiv, Odesa and elsewhere on seizing administration buildings and on funding, and says the unrest should look grassroots [R17].
- **Putin, 17 Dec 2015:** "We never said there were no people there who were carrying out certain tasks, including in the military sphere" [R18].
- **ECHR (25 Jan 2023)**: Russian military personnel were present "in an active capacity" in Donbas **from April 2014**; large-scale deployment of regular troops **"at the very latest" from August 2014**; weapons were supplied "from the earliest days"; Russia had **effective control from 11 May 2014** [R19]. Grand Chamber judgment, **9 July 2025**: unanimous; Russia responsible for patterns of violations from 11 May 2014 to 16 Sep 2022, **including the downing of MH17** [R20].

EXAMPLE Compare the résumés. The DPR's first "defence minister" was an FSB veteran from Moscow. Its first "prime minister" was a Moscow PR man. Meanwhile Volodymyr Rybak, a Horlivka city councillor born in Donbas, tried to raise the Ukrainian flag over his town hall and was found murdered on 17 April 2014. SBU intercepts tie Girkin's and Bezler's people to his death [R32]. Ask the audience which of those men was "the local".

ZINGER ***When the arsonist signs a confession, stop blaming the house.***

6. The 11 May 2014 "referendum": theatre with ammunition

CLAIM The only "vote" that showed Donbas wanted out was run by armed men, without voter lists, observers or security on the ballots, and with the result decided before the count.

NUMBERS

- Claimed result: Donetsk **89%** yes on **~75%** turnout (2,252,867 yes vs 256,040 no); Luhansk **96.2%** [R21].
- Ukraine's Interior Ministry estimated turnout at about **32%** (Donetsk) and **24%** (Luhansk). Label these as Ukrainian government estimates [R21].
- SBU intercept, 5 May 2014, six days before the vote: Russian neo-Nazi Alexander Barkashov tells a DPR organiser to "tabulate" **89%**. That is the exact figure later announced [R21].
- **100,000** pre-marked "yes" ballots seized near Sloviansk before the vote [R21].
- Multiple voting filmed by international media; a Bild reporter followed one man who voted **8 times** [R21]. Mariupol, a city of about 500,000, got **4 polling stations** [R21].
- **Putin himself** asked on 7 May for the vote to be postponed. It went ahead anyway [R21].

EXAMPLE On the same day, a counter-initiative collected votes on joining neighbouring Dnipropetrovsk oblast, under Ukraine. Ukraine's Central Election Commission spokesman cited about **2.88 million** participants and **69.1%** in favour [R21]. Treat it as an informal exercise too, but if the opponent accepts one unregulated vote, they have to accept the other.

ZINGER ***Ballots with no voter lists, counted by men with rifles, aren't democracy. They're a hostage situation with a press release.***

7. The control group: Kharkiv, Dnipro, Mariupol, Odesa

CLAIM If "Russian-speaking" explained the occupation, the occupation would have followed the language map. It followed the routes of the Russian squads.

NUMBERS

- Kharkiv city: **65.9%** Russian native speakers (2001) [R6]. In April 2014 only **16.1%** of Kharkiv oblast backed joining Russia [R8].
- Kharkiv's regional administration was seized on 6 April 2014 and a "Kharkiv People's Republic" was proclaimed on the 7th. Police cleared the building on **8 April** and arrested about **65** people [R31]. Without an armed Russian squad, it was over in about 48 hours.

- Dnipropetrovsk oblast: only **6.9%** for joining Russia, **84.1%** against [R8]. It never fell.
- Mariupol: **89.6%** Russian native speakers, temporarily held by separatists in spring 2014 and **retaken by Ukraine on 13 June 2014** [R30][R6]. Sloviansk was retaken on **5 July 2014**, after which Girkin's men fell back to Donetsk [R14].
- Girkin admits the pattern himself: without his squad "it all would have ended like in Kharkiv or Odesa" [R13].

EXAMPLE Run the experiment. Kharkiv and Donetsk had the same Soviet industry, the same language mix, the same Russian TV and the same Glazyev-style instructions [R17]. One variable differs: in Donetsk oblast an armed group from Russia crossed the border and took a town. Different variable, different outcome. That's not a culture; that's a cause.

ZINGER ***Same language, same factories, same TV. The only thing different was Russian guns, and that's exactly where the map turned red.***

8. Donbas natives on Ukraine's side: the faces of the counter-argument

CLAIM The best evidence against "Donbas is pro-Russian" is the long list of Donbas people who paid the highest price for Ukraine.

NUMBERS

- **Ivan Dziuba**, born in Mykolaivka, Donetsk oblast, spoke Russian until about 17. He became a Soviet dissident and wrote *Internationalism or Russification?* (1965), the classic indictment of Soviet language policy. Hero of Ukraine [R34].
- **Vasyl Stus**, born in Podillia but raised in Stalino (today's Donetsk), educated in Russian-language schools. One of Ukraine's greatest poets; died in the Soviet camp Perm-36 in 1985 [R35].
- **Serhiy Zhadan**, born in Starobilsk, Luhansk oblast. Ukraine's best-known living writer; joined the 13th Khartia Brigade of the National Guard in June 2024 [R33].
- **Stanislav Aseyev**, Donetsk journalist. Abducted by the DPR in 2017 and held in the Izoliatsia prison; wrote *The Torture Camp on Paradise Street* [R36].
- **Volodymyr Rybak**, Horlivka city councillor. Murdered in April 2014 after trying to raise the Ukrainian flag [R32].
- **Donbas Battalion** (2014), a volunteer unit formed for the region's defence. Its founder, Semen Semenchenko, is ethnically Russian, born in Sevastopol, and studied in Donetsk [R37]. Say "Donetsk-educated", not "Donbas-born".

Unverified, so don't claim it: there is no reliable published count of Donbas natives serving in Ukraine's forces. Use named people, not a made-up number.

EXAMPLE Dziuba and Stus are the perfect pair: two boys from Donbas who grew up in Russian, and became the voices the KGB feared most for defending Ukrainian. Survivorship bias works in reverse here: Moscow spent decades jailing the best of Donbas and then claimed the region had no Ukrainians.

ZINGER ***Donbas is not the problem in this story. Donbas is the proof.***

9. Voting with their feet: where people fled

CLAIM When the "liberators" arrived, more people from Donbas fled to Ukraine than to Russia.

NUMBERS

- UNHCR, 6 Feb 2015: **980,000** registered internally displaced people in Ukraine, versus about **600,000** who sought asylum or other legal stay abroad, **mainly in Russia** [R27].
- Ministry of Social Policy: **1,427,000** registered IDPs from Crimea and Donbas (12 Feb 2018); **1,512,435** (2 Jan 2019) [R28].

Caveat to say before they do: the IDP registry includes some people who registered so they could keep receiving Ukrainian pensions while still living in occupied areas, and the "abroad" figure includes people who already lived in Russia. Say "registered IDPs" and use the UNHCR comparison as directional, not exact.

EXAMPLE Imagine your city is "freed" by people who say they share your language and your values, and your answer is to pack the car and drive toward the "oppressor". About a million people did exactly that in the first ten months.

ZINGER ***People vote with their feet, and in 2014 they walked toward Kyiv.***

10. After 2014: occupation didn't convert people

CLAIM Eight years of occupation, propaganda and passport handouts did not produce the "Russian Donbas" Moscow promised.

NUMBERS

- ZOiS (Berlin), 2019, survey inside the occupied areas: about **55%** preferred to belong to Ukraine (24% without special status, 31% with autonomy); joining Russia: 18% without autonomy, 27% with [R12].
- Same study, government-controlled Donbas: about **65%** wanted reintegration without any special status [R12].
- KIIS 2021–Feb 2022 combined surveys, government-controlled Donetsk oblast: **10%** wanted unification with Russia, **86%** wanted independence [R9].
- 2019 presidential runoff, government-controlled Donetsk oblast: Zelensky **86.94%**, Poroshenko 10.59%; Luhansk: Zelensky **89.44%** [R29]. Zelensky is a Russian-speaking Ukrainian from Kryvyi Rih, so this vote says nothing about wanting Russia.
- KIIS, May 2022, three months into the full-scale invasion: **68%** in the East rejected any territorial concessions, **19%** accepted them. Among people then living under occupation, **77%** rejected concessions [R11].

EXAMPLE Even the ZOiS figure for joining Russia (18% + 27%) was measured after five years without independent media, with Ukrainian TV switched off and pro-Ukrainian residents expelled, jailed or fled. If you have to empty a region of its dissenters to approach a majority, you don't have a majority. You have a filtration camp.

ZINGER ***Moscow had eight years and every lever of power, and still couldn't get Donbas to like it.***

11. Own the inconvenient numbers before they do

Peterson's rule: steelman the opponent first. These are real; say them first, then reframe.

Their real number	Your reframe
KIIS Apr 2014: **72.5%** in Donetsk preferred the Customs Union over the EU [R8]	Wanting a trade bloc is not asking to be invaded. Most Brexit voters didn't want the US Army in Manchester. Same poll: 52.2% against joining Russia.
KIIS Apr 2014: **38.4%** in Donetsk wanted federalisation [R8]	41.1% wanted a decentralised unitary state, inside Ukraine. Both groups were asking for more local power within Ukraine. Neither asked for the DPR.
KIIS Feb 2014: **33.2%** in Donetsk wanted Ukraine and Russia merged [R7]	That was the peak, it was a minority, and it was a vote for merging the whole country, not for Russian rule over Donetsk. It fell to 10% by 2021–22 [R9].
2019 first round: Yuriy Boyko (Opposition Platform) **36.87%** in Donetsk [R29]	Voting for a Ukrainian party in a Ukrainian election is the opposite of separatism. In the runoff, 86.94% of the same oblast voted for Zelensky.
Party of Regions elites and local communists stoked the 2014 unrest; the 2004 Sievierodonetsk "autonomy" congress	That's an elite story, not a popular one. Oligarch-politicians played the separatist card for leverage, and the guns still came from Russia.
June 1993 Donbas miners' strike demanded regional autonomy [R24]	It ended in negotiation and elections, with no one taking hostages. That's how Ukrainians settle disputes; in 2014 Russia chose a different method.

12. Their argument / your answer

They say…	You answer…
"Donbas is Russian-speaking, so it's Russian."	2001 census: 56.9% ethnic Ukrainian in Donetsk, 58.0% in Luhansk [R2]. 58.7% of Donetsk Ukrainians speak Russian natively [R3]. Kharkiv city is 66% Russian-native and Mariupol 90%, and neither fell in 2014 without Russian guns [R6][R30][R31].
"It was a civil war."	The man who started it says he did: "I pulled the trigger of war" [R13]. Russian FSB veteran as defence minister, Moscow PR man as PM [R14][R15]. The ECHR found Russian effective control from 11 May 2014 [R19]; the MH17 court found Russia controlled the DPR [R14].

"The people rose up against the Kyiv junta."	Only 18.1% in Donetsk supported seizing buildings [R8]. Kharkiv's "uprising" was cleared by police in about 48 hours [R31]. Uprisings don't need Muscovites to run them.
"89% voted for independence in May 2014."	The 89% was dictated on a phone call six days before the vote [R21]. 100,000 pre-marked ballots, no voter lists, one man voting 8 times. Even Putin asked to postpone it.
"Kyiv attacked its own people first."	Order of events: armed men from Crimea took Sloviansk on 12 April; the first person killed was a Ukrainian SBU officer on 13 April; a Ukrainian councillor was murdered on 17 April [R14][R32]. The state responded to an armed seizure.
"Russia was only protecting Russian speakers."	Mariupol, 89.6% Russian-native, was "protected" into rubble in 2022 [R6]. 980,000 people had already fled the "protection" to Ukraine by 2015 [R27].
"Ethnic Russians wanted Russia."	In 1991 about 55% of ethnic Russians in Ukraine voted for independence [R39]. In Feb 2014 only 31.8% of ethnic Russians wanted a single state with Russia [R7].
"Donbas was always nostalgic for the USSR."	Donbas miners went on strike against the USSR in 1989 (173 of 226 mines) and in 1991 demanded Gorbachev's resignation [R24][R25]. Then they voted 84% for independence [R1].
"There were no Russian troops."	Putin, Dec 2015: people "carrying out certain tasks, including in the military sphere" [R18]. ECHR: active Russian personnel from April 2014, regular troops by August 2014 at the latest [R19].
"Polls show they wanted to leave."	Every credible 2014 poll shows a minority: 27.5% Donetsk, 30.3% Luhansk [R8]. Pew: 70% of the East wanted to stay united [R10]. By 2021–22: 10% [R9].
"You can't trust Ukrainian sources."	Then use Pew (US) [R10], ZOiS (Germany) [R12], UNHCR [R27], the ECHR [R19], a Dutch court [R14], and Girkin's own interview in a Russian newspaper [R13].

13. Accuracy guardrails (what not to say)

- Don't say the 1989 strike **started** in Donbas. It started in **Kuzbass** (Mezhdurechensk); Donbas was a main centre [R22].
- Don't say "500,000 Donbas miners". 500,000+ was **strike participants in Ukraine** [R24]; 400,000+ was the USSR-wide figure for miners [R22]. For Donbas itself, use "173 of 226 collieries".
- Don't claim Donbas had **zero** pro-Russian sentiment. Say: a real minority, never a majority, and never a justification.
- The 32% / 24% referendum turnout figures are **Ukrainian government estimates**; label them that way.
- Pew's "East" is a macro-region, not only Donetsk and Luhansk. Say "eastern Ukraine".
- No verified number exists for Donbas natives in Ukraine's army. Use names.
- The 2019 parliamentary vote shares for Opposition Platform by oblast were **not verified** for these notes. Use the presidential figures instead.

14. Timeline

Date	Event	Src
10–11 Jul 1989	Miners' strike begins in Mezhdurechensk, Kuzbass	[R22]
15–20 Jul 1989	Donbas joins; 173 of 226 collieries out; Soviet commission arrives in Donetsk on 20 July	[R24]
Sep 1989	Shcherbytsky removed as Ukraine's Communist Party boss	[R22]
Mar–May 1991	Second all-Union miners' strike; Ukrainian miners demand Gorbachev's resignation and constitutional status for Ukraine's sovereignty declaration	[R25]
1 Dec 1991	Independence referendum: Donetsk 83.90%, Luhansk 83.86% yes	[R1]
Feb 2014	KIIS: 33.2% in Donetsk for merging Ukraine with Russia; national figure 12.5%	[R7]
6–8 Apr 2014	Kharkiv administration seized; "KhPR" proclaimed; cleared by police, about 65 arrested	[R31]
12 Apr 2014	Girkin's ~50 men from Crimea seize Sloviansk	[R14]
13 Apr 2014	SBU officer Hennadiy Bilichenko killed: the first combat death	[R14]
8–16 Apr 2014	KIIS: 27.5% Donetsk / 30.3% Luhansk for joining Russia; majorities against	[R8]
17 Apr 2014	Horlivka councillor Volodymyr Rybak found murdered	[R32]
11 May 2014	Sham "referendums"; ECHR dates Russian effective control from this day	[R19][R21]
16 May 2014	Muscovite Borodai becomes DPR "PM"; Girkin becomes "defence minister"	[R15]
13 Jun 2014	Ukraine retakes Mariupol	[R30]
5 Jul 2014	Ukraine retakes Sloviansk	[R14]
17 Jul 2014	MH17 shot down; 298 killed	[R14]
Aug 2014	Large-scale deployment of Russian regular troops, "at the very latest" (ECHR)	[R19]
20 Nov 2014	Girkin: "I'm the one who pulled the trigger of war"	[R13]
17 Dec 2015	Putin admits Russian people "in the military sphere" in Donbas	[R18]
2019	ZOiS: ~55% in occupied areas prefer belonging to Ukraine	[R12]
24 Feb 2022	Full-scale Russian invasion	n/a
17 Nov 2022	Girkin convicted in absentia over MH17	[R14]
25 Jan 2023 / 9 Jul 2025	ECHR admissibility decision / Grand Chamber judgment against Russia	[R19][R20]

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See also: the three HackerNoon articles listed on page 1.